

“Ladies and Gentleman, The Beatles”

IS THERE ANY greater gap between expert opinion and subsequent history than The Beatles?

AllMusic sums up the Fab Four as: “The most popular and influential rock act of all time, a band that blazed several new trails for popular music.”¹⁹ That’s obvious today, but it was not the consensus early in their career.

Amusing details were recounted in *The Better Letter*, Bob Seawright’s twice monthly take on the world. Nobody skewers humanity’s cognitive failings better than Seawright does. He giddily recounted the early reviews of The Beatles when they first came to America.²⁰ At the time, the band had five singles in Britain’s Top 20, three of which hit #1—all in 1963. Their debut album, *Please Please Me*, held the top spot on Britain’s charts for 30 weeks, displaced only by their next album, *With the Beatles*.

Despite the sensation they were causing in Great Britain, their record label (EMI) could not persuade its American counterpart (Capitol) to release any of the band’s singles in the States. Dave Dexter was the man in charge of international A&R for Capitol, and ostensibly an industry expert on the public’s musical tastes. He repeatedly rejected The Beatles singles, calling them “generally amateurish and unappealing.” One after another, Dexter vetoed those singles tearing up the charts in the UK, starting with “Please Please Me” and “She Loves You.”

Ed Sullivan had also turned down the Fab Four (twice) for his show. By coincidence, he was at London (now Heathrow) Airport, when he witnessed Beatlemania first hand. The band was returning home from a tour in Sweden, greeted by a raucous, screaming mob of teenage girls. That convinced Sullivan to book the lads on his show.

The Ed Sullivan Show was a huge platform for breaking new acts, and Capitol decided to release “I Want to Hold Your Hand” a few weeks before